Forked Tongues

ANTI-HINDI AGITATION, 1965

Madras State

46TH ANNIVERSARY

YOUTH UPRISINGS

The anti-Hindi sentiment gained traction as the day of the switchover (January 26, 1965) to Hindi came near

The Union government's efforts to impose Hindi as the sole official language after 1965 met with resistance in the erstwhile Madras state, which soon snowballed into a violent agitation. The anti-Hindi agitation gained traction with students out on the streets as the day of the switchover (January 26, 1965) to Hindi neared. On January 25, riots broke out in Madurai sparked off by a minor altercation between agitating students and workers of the ruling Congress. It soon spread across the state and continued for two months. The fledgling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) rallied the youth, harped on the self-respect of Tamils, and kept the situation on the boil. The 70-odd deaths in police firing gathered more support for the DMK. Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri's assurance that English would continue as the official language as long as the non-Hindi-speaking states wanted led to the end of the agitation. But political convulsions continued and enabled the DMK to come to power in the 1967 assembly poll, trouncing the Congress, which never recovered after the loss. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

THE DRAVIDIAN RISE The anti-Hindi agitation laid the seeds for the dominance of Dravidian parties in Tamil Nadu politics, reimagining the Union-state paradigm on relative rights and governance